

Asking for and giving advice

Teaching guide

Ask a focused question and offer a useful option.

Understand the distinction

Give enough context for the listener to understand the problem. State your goal or constraint, then ask a specific question: I have ten minutes. Which route would you suggest? Advice is normally uncountable: some advice, a piece of advice.

When responding, offer an option and a reason. Could can present a possibility; should can make a stronger recommendation. Ask a clarifying question when information is missing. Acknowledge limits rather than giving confident advice on something you do not know.

Compare the patterns

CONTEXT

I need to reach the station by nine.

State the goal and constraint.

QUESTION

Which route would you recommend?

Ask something the listener can answer.

OPTION + REASON

You could take the bus because it stops nearby.

Offer an option with a relevant reason.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Correct this: Can you give me an advice?

2. Which question is more focused: What should I do? / Which bus goes to the station?

3. What should you do before advising if the deadline is unclear?

Use it in your own life

Write a short exchange with context, a question, and an option with a reason.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. Can you give me some advice?

Advice is normally uncountable.

2. Which bus goes to the station?

It specifies the information needed.

3. Ask when the person needs to finish or arrive.

Clarify the missing constraint.

One possible response

I need a quiet place to study. Where would you suggest? You could try the library because it has a quiet room.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-44.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Write a short exchange with context, a question, and an option with a reason.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.